

In the atrial chamber of the former Civic Harmonization Annex—its cornices ulcerated by ten thousand sleepless memoranda—the light falls in cantilevered slats, filtered through mesh-veined glass installed during a restoration campaign that never completed its third phase (the ribbon was cut by an unrecognized official; the scissors rusted mid-air). Beneath the flaking mural of The Procedural Saints—painted in ulcerous ochres and draft-ink blue—there stands a figure in municipal robes (or perhaps gauze; the fibers smell of long-extinguished toner), reading aloud from Circular 11/□, a document that mandates the soft exorcism of stairwells and forbids the naming of certain hinges. No one listens. That is the rite.

Every fifteen minutes, a chime—mimicking the bell tone of pre-amalgamation fire alarms—announces the failure of another structural concept: threshold, support, bearing. The walls sigh in ligamented creaks, leaking faint glimmers of orthodontic brass—not as a metal, but as an odor of failed confidence, sharp and apologetic. Below, in the building's stomach, the elevator shaft digests its last cable, having been fed petitions written on sintered paper ash, folded into anatomical diagrams of extinct limbs (e.g., the parliate flange, the dorsal veto).

A fence of forgotten barricades surrounds the atrium, each welded sign contradicting the next: ENTER FOR SAFETY // EXIT UNDER PENALTY. One reads, simply, This Was Meant, though the typeface has collapsed into a glyphic bruise, half-font, half-fungus. Children—though no births have occurred here since the annex's disbanding—crawl the rails in mime of deliberation, smearing chalk sigils onto the floor tiles (each tile inscribed with a defunct departmental seal: Drought Oversight, Sentience Taxonomy, Harmonic Enforcement).

Above all this, the dome—a collapsed lung of stained glass—inhalates dust and exhales names that were never entered into minutes: Chairperson Hush, Notary Second, The Abstentionist. Their voices echo in recursive denial—not now, not never, not here, not then—as if refusing time its quorum.

And so the ritual repeats: the reading, the chime, the crawling, the exhalation—each cycle more faithful to its erosion, more obedient to its own annulment. Even the air has turned votive—damp with municipal dusk and the delicate bile of post-approval regret.

Here, where bylaws breed in mildew and tape, language is both the lock and its unmaking. The final clause of Circular 11/□ reads: This shall not be interpreted—a recursion so strict, it forgets what was ever meant to begin.

The vestibule remains. Not waiting. Remembering the wrong shape of entry.